Transforming the BRICs into the BRICS

The story of South Africa's involvement in the BRICS runs through its relations with China. South Africa was invited into the BRICS club in December 2010 at the behest of China, host of the 2011 BRICS Summit. Clearly, China, which has invested heavily in sourcing food and raw materials in Africa, perceived the advantages of a gateway to the continent. It may have chosen South Africa for its moral and normative stature, derived from President Mandela and the ANC (the party that has provided all of its postapartheid chief executives to date), but certainly also for its economic and financial advantages. South Africa, with a population of just under 50 million, is not the most populous country in Africa; in fact, it ranks sixth, after Nigeria, Ethiopia, Egypt, Congo, and Tanzania. South Africa has the second-largest economy in Africa, after Nigeria, ranked by nominal GDP, and falls to third, following both Nigeria and Egypt, when purchasing power parity (PPP) calculation of GDP is employed. Nonetheless, South Africa has the largest industrial base in the continent, and a stable democracy, despite raucous domestic political competition.

Initially, the South Africans declined to look a gift horse in the mouth, expressing enthusiasm, despite some initial confusion, about their inclusion in the BRICS club. Some analysts suggest that, as in Brazil, membership in South-South groupings[268] such as the IBSA Dialogue Forum and the BRICS is useful for a government concerned about maintaining its leftist, redistributive, and even anticapitalist credentials, while pursuing fairly conventional macroeconomic policies at home.[269] Also as in Brazil, BRICS excitement was perhaps highest through 2012 or 2013. President Zuma has attended all the BRICS summits since 2011, and his government was proud to host the Durban BRICS Summit in 2013. Nonetheless, earlier ambitious plans to host a grand China-Africa Summit following the BRICS meeting were scaled back to a short and bland encounter with twelve (of fifty-two) African heads of state and President Xi, held on the final afternoon of the BRICS Summit, while Xi also made individual stops in the Republic of Congo and Tanzania.[270] The Durban Summit brought little progress on defining the new BRICS financial institutions, instead focusing on political declarations, including criticism of Western sanctions on Syria.[271]

Thereafter, South Africa's participation in the BRICS slowed. From the 2013 Durban Summit through 2016, there was less grateful awe and more